490.LIFE · THE WHOLE STORY · LESSON 18 OF 26

Return: The Second Temple and the Silent Years

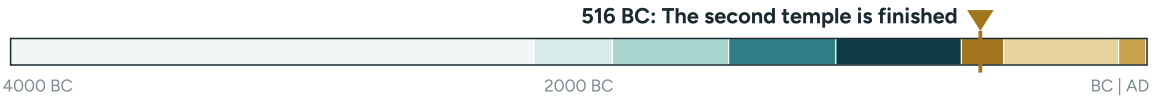
Ezra 1; 3; 6; Nehemiah 1; 4; 8; Malachi 3–4



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October 18, 2026

YOU ARE HERE · LESSON 18



Introduction: Home, but Not Yet Home

Lesson 17 ended with God's people weeping by the rivers of Babylon and a promise: after seventy years, God would bring them back. This lesson tells how he kept that promise, and what happened next.

The exiles came home. They rebuilt the temple and the walls of Jerusalem. They gathered to hear God's law read aloud, wept over it, and then were told to rejoice. But the old problems came back too. The last prophet of the Old Testament, Malachi, scolded them for the same half-hearted worship that had marked the generations before the exile. And then something strange happened. Heaven went quiet. For about four hundred years, no new prophet spoke and no new book of Scripture was written.

This is the last lesson in the Old Testament part of our story. On our timeline: the first exiles return in 538 BC, the second temple is finished in 516 BC, Nehemiah rebuilds the walls in 445 BC, Malachi prophesies around 430 BC, and then come the silent years, until a baby is born in Bethlehem around 5 BC.

The Word: Return

> **Zechariah 1:3** *"Therefore say to them, Thus declares the LORD of hosts: Return to me, says the LORD of hosts, and I will return to you, says the LORD of hosts."*

שׁוּב *(shuv, "return, turn back")*

to turn around and go back

Going home	+	Turning back
a journey		*a heart*
Exiles returning from Babylon to the land God promised.		The Old Testament's main word for repentance: turning from sin back to God.

Payoff: The same Hebrew word means both. That is the point of this lesson. The exiles could return to the land and still not return to God. God wanted both. And even our turning is his gift: "Restore us to yourself, O LORD, that we may be restored!" (Lam. 5:21). "Return to me… and I will return to you" (Zech. 1:3; Mal. 3:7). Jesus told a story about a son who came home, and "while he was still a long way off, his father saw him and felt compassion, and ran and embraced him" (Luke 15:20). That is what God is like when people return to him.

Part One: Rebuilding the House

In 539 BC, the Persian king Cyrus conquered Babylon. The next year he issued a stunning decree: the Jews could go home and rebuild their temple. Ezra tells us why: "the LORD stirred up the spirit of Cyrus king of Persia" (Ezra 1:1). More than a century earlier, God had even named him through the prophet Isaiah: "who says of Cyrus, 'He is my shepherd, and he shall fulfill all my purpose'" (Isa. 44:28).

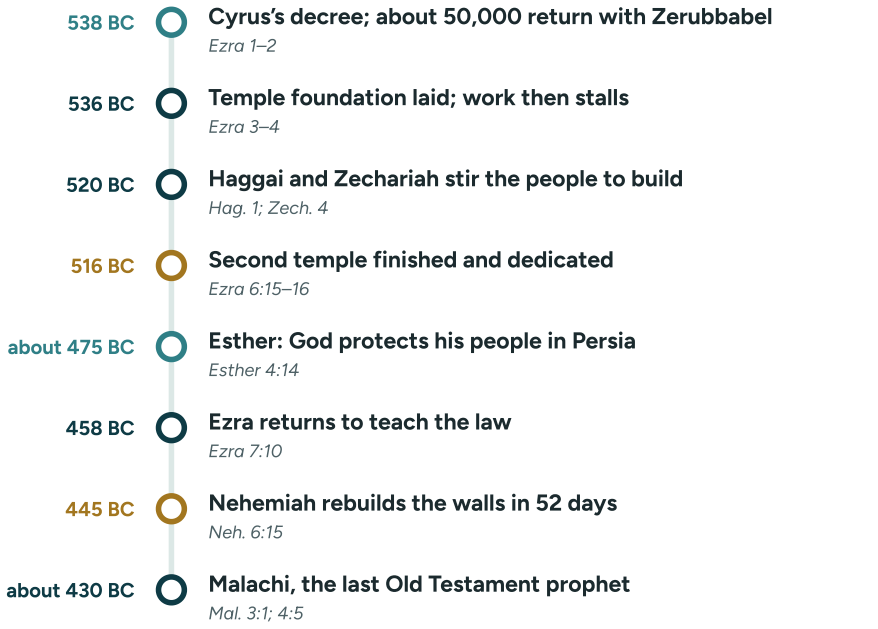
About fifty thousand people made the long journey home (Ezra 2:64–65), led by Zerubbabel, a descendant of David, and Joshua the high priest (Ezra calls him Jeshua). They rebuilt the altar first and began offering sacrifices again. Then they laid the foundation of a new temple. It was a moment of mixed emotions:

> **Ezra 3:11–12** *"And all the people shouted with a great shout when they praised the LORD, because the foundation of the house of the LORD was laid. But many of the priests and Levites and heads of fathers' houses, old men who had seen the first house, wept with a loud voice when they saw the foundation of this house being laid, though many shouted aloud for joy."*

Others rejoiced at a new beginning. The old men wept, because they remembered Solomon's temple, and this one looked like nothing beside it (Hag. 2:3). Then enemies in the land opposed the work, and the building stopped for about sixteen years (4:4–5, 24).

God sent two prophets to get it moving again. Haggai asked a pointed question: "Is it a time for you yourselves to dwell in your paneled houses, while this house lies in ruins?" (Hag. 1:4). To those who thought the new temple was nothing compared to the old one, he gave a promise: "The latter glory of this house shall be greater than the former" (2:9). Zechariah encouraged their leader: "Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts" (Zech. 4:6). In 516 BC, about seventy years after Solomon's temple burned, the second temple was finished, and the people "celebrated the dedication of this house of God with joy" (Ezra 6:16).

Coming Home (Ezra, Nehemiah, Haggai, Malachi)



"Return to me, and I will return to you" (Mal. 3:7).

Part Two: Walls and the Word

Decades later, many Jews were still living in the Persian Empire. The book of Esther comes from this period. God is never named in it, yet he quietly saves his people through a Jewish queen who is placed in the palace "for such a time as this" (Esther 4:14).

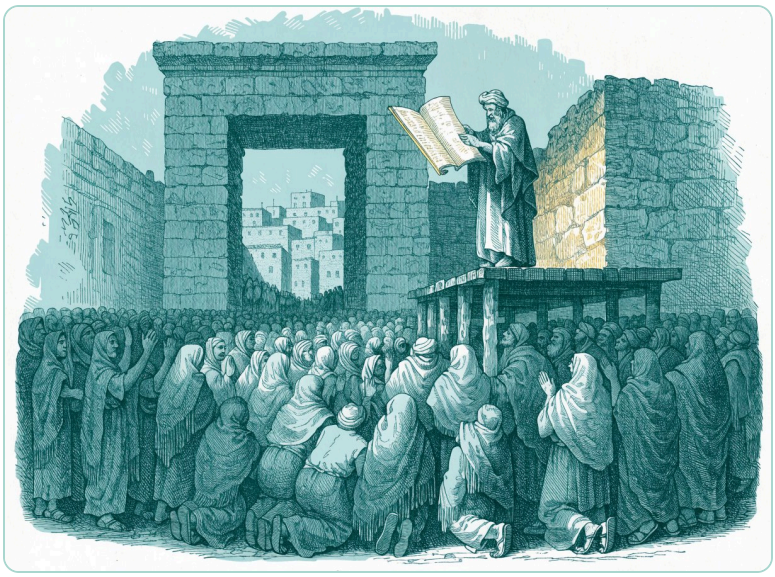
Around 458 BC a priest and scholar named Ezra led another group home. The Bible describes him in one great sentence: "For Ezra had set his heart to study the Law of the LORD, and to do it and to teach his statutes and rules in Israel" (Ezra 7:10). Study it, do it, teach it, in that order.

Then in 445 BC a man named Nehemiah, who served as cupbearer to the Persian king, heard that Jerusalem's walls were still broken down. "As soon as I heard these words I sat down and wept and mourned for days, and I continued fasting and praying" (Neh. 1:4). The king gave him permission to go and rebuild. Enemies mocked and threatened. So Nehemiah organized the workers so that "each labored on the work with one hand and held his weapon with the other" (4:17). They "prayed to our God and set a guard" (4:9). He told the people, "Remember the Lord, who is great and awesome, and fight for your brothers" (4:14). The wall was finished in just fifty-two days, and even their enemies "perceived that this work had been accomplished with the help of our God" (6:15–16).



"Each labored on the work with one hand and held his weapon with the other" (Neh. 4:17).

When the wall was done, the people gathered in the square and asked Ezra to bring out the Book of the Law. He stood on a wooden platform and read from early morning until midday, and "the ears of all the people were attentive" (8:3). When he opened the book, everyone stood. The Levites helped, reading "clearly, and they gave the sense, so that the people understood the reading" (8:8). And the people wept as they heard God's word and realized how far they had fallen. But their leaders told them, "do not be grieved, for the joy of the LORD is your strength" (8:10).



"They read from the book, from the Law of God, clearly, and they gave the sense, so that the people understood the reading" (Neh. 8:8).

Part Three: The Last Prophet

Sadly, the revival did not last. When Nehemiah came back after a trip to Persia, he found the people had stopped supporting the temple and were breaking the Sabbath and marrying people who worshiped other gods (Neh. 13). The prophet Malachi, around 430 BC, describes a people who were going through the motions. The priests were offering blind and sick animals on God's altar, the leftovers they would never give their governor (Mal. 1:8). God said, "If then I am a father, where is my honor?" (1:6).

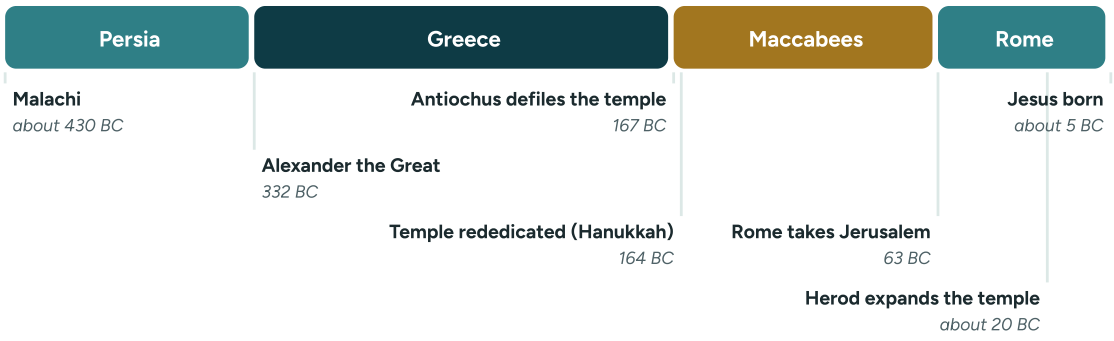
Yet even Malachi is full of grace. "For I the LORD do not change; therefore you, O children of Jacob, are not consumed.... Return to me, and I will return to you" (3:6–7). And he closes the Old Testament, as our Bibles arrange it, looking forward. God would send a messenger to prepare the way, and then "the Lord whom you seek will suddenly come to his temple" (3:1). "But for you who fear my name, the sun of righteousness shall rise with healing in its wings" (4:2). And before that great day, "I will send you Elijah the prophet" (4:5).

And then the voice of prophecy went silent.

Part Four: The Silent Years

Between Malachi and the birth of Jesus are about four hundred years. No new prophet spoke, and no new book was added to the Old Testament. Christians sometimes call this time the intertestamental period, or simply the silent years. But silence did not mean God was absent. He was setting the stage.

The Silent Years: About 400 Years Between the Testaments



Greek became the common language of the eastern Mediterranean; the Old Testament was translated into Greek; Roman roads tied the empire together

"When the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son" (Gal. 4:4).

The Greeks. In 332 BC Alexander the Great took the land of Israel on his way to conquering the whole Persian Empire, and Greek became the common language of the eastern Mediterranean world. Jewish scholars translated the Old Testament into Greek, and that translation, called the Septuagint, became the

Bible many of the first Christians read. The New Testament itself would be written in Greek, so that it could travel everywhere.

The Maccabees. In 167 BC a Greek king named Antiochus IV tried to stamp out Jewish faith. He banned the law, outlawed circumcision, and had pigs sacrificed on the temple altar. (This history comes from 1 Maccabees, a Jewish book written soon after, not part of our Bible.) A family of Jewish fighters called the Maccabees rebelled, retook Jerusalem, and rededicated the temple in 164 BC. Jews still remember that at Hanukkah, the Feast of Dedication, which Jesus himself attended (John 10:22–23).

The Romans. In 63 BC the Roman general Pompey took Jerusalem. Rome kept a tense peace across its empire, and built the roads the apostles would one day walk. Rome made a man named Herod king of the Jews, and around 20 BC Herod began a huge rebuilding and expansion of the second temple. That is the temple Jesus would walk into.

And all through those years, in synagogues and homes, faithful people waited for God to keep his promises. Luke tells us about one of them, an old man named Simeon, "righteous and devout, waiting for the consolation of Israel" (Luke 2:25). Paul looks back on it all and says, "But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son" (Gal. 4:4). He was right on time.

THREAD WATCH

GOD WITH HIS PEOPLE The second temple had no ark of the covenant. It was probably lost or destroyed when Babylon took Jerusalem, though Scripture never tells us exactly what happened to it (see Jer. 3:16). And Scripture never records the cloud of glory filling it, as it filled the tabernacle and Solomon's temple. Yet Haggai promised its glory would be greater than the first. That promise was kept when a baby was carried into its courts, and old Simeon took him in his arms (Luke 2:27–32). The glory had come back, in a person.

THE LAMB The sacrifices began again on the rebuilt altar. But Malachi exposed how hollow they had become, and he looked ahead to a day when "in every place incense will be offered to my name, and a pure offering" among the nations (Mal. 1:11). That day came through Jesus, the Lamb whose one sacrifice opened the way for people from every nation to worship God in spirit and truth (John 4:23; Heb. 10:14).

A Note on "Seventy Sevens"

During the exile, Daniel received a vision about how long God's people would wait: "Seventy weeks are decreed about your people and your holy city, to finish the transgression, to put an end to sin, and to atone for iniquity, to bring in everlasting righteousness" (Dan. 9:24). The word translated "weeks" means "sevens," and most interpreters understand it as seventy sevens of years: 490 years. Christians have counted these years in different ways, and the details are debated. But many Reformed interpreters see the heart of this prophecy fulfilled in Jesus, who came to "put an end to sin" and "atone for iniquity." Some readers notice another connection. When Peter asks how often he must forgive, Jesus answers, "seventy-seven times" (Matt. 18:22). The Greek can also be read "seventy times seven," which the ESV gives in a footnote, and that reading comes to 490. Many scholars hear an echo of Lamech, who boasted of revenge "seventy-sevenfold" (Gen. 4:24), turned upside down into forgiveness. Daniel's prophecy and

Peter's question are not about the same thing, so we should hold the link loosely. But both point the same way: in Jesus, God deals with sin completely, and those he forgives learn to forgive without keeping count.

CORE DOCTRINE 18 OF 26

The Faithfulness of God

God always keeps his word. He promised to bring his people home after seventy years, and he did. He promised to send a Messiah, and through four hundred silent years he did not forget. Every promise of God finds its yes in Jesus Christ.

KEY VERSES

Jeremiah 29:10; Lamentations 3:22–23; 2 Corinthians 1:20; 2 Timothy 2:13

WHAT THE CHURCH CONFESSES

"God is a Spirit, infinite, eternal, and unchangeable, in his being, wisdom, power, holiness, justice, goodness, and truth." (Westminster Shorter Catechism 4)

WHY IT MATTERS

When God seems silent, he has not forgotten you. The God who kept his promises through centuries will keep his promises to you.

The Turn: The Silence Breaks

After four hundred years of silence, God spoke again. An angel came to an old priest named Zechariah, and then to a young woman named Mary. Zechariah's son grew up to be a voice in the wilderness. Mark begins his Gospel by quoting Malachi and Isaiah: "Behold, I send my messenger before your face, who will prepare your way, the voice of one crying in the wilderness: 'Prepare the way of the Lord, make his paths straight'" (Mark 1:2–3). That messenger was John the Baptist, who came in the spirit of Elijah, just as Malachi promised. And right behind him came "the Lord whom you seek."

Jesus did come suddenly to his temple, just as Malachi said. As a baby, he was carried into it, and Simeon said, "my eyes have seen your salvation" (Luke 2:30). As a man, he rode into Jerusalem on a donkey, exactly as Zechariah had foretold: "Behold, your king is coming to you… humble and mounted on a donkey" (Zech. 9:9; Matt. 21:5). Then he cleansed the temple, driving out the money-changers: "My house shall be called a house of prayer" (Matt. 21:13). And he said, "Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it up," speaking about his body (John 2:19, 21). When he died, "the curtain of the temple was torn in two, from top to bottom" (Mark 15:38). The way into God's presence was open.

The exiles came home to the land, but many never truly came home to God. The same invitation stands for you: "Return to me, and I will return to you." You do not need to rebuild anything first or prove anything. Like the son in Jesus' story, you only need to turn around and come. The Father runs to meet everyone who comes. Turn from your sin, trust Jesus, and come home.

Living It: Six Practices for This Week

1. **Study, do, teach.** Pick one short passage this week. Study it, do one thing it says, and share it with one person (Ezra 7:10).

2. **Consider your ways.** Haggai told people who were busy with their own houses while God's lay in ruins, "Consider your ways" (Hag. 1:5). Where does God come last in your time or money?

3. **Build with both hands.** Name one good work God has given you, and one threat to it. Pray, then keep working.

4. **Find your joy.** Read Nehemiah 8:1–12. Let God's word convict you, then let it lead you to "the joy of the LORD."

5. **Wait well.** Is God silent in some area of your life? Like Simeon, keep worshiping and watching. God is never late.

6. **Memorize Zechariah 4:6.** "Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts."

Before Lesson 19: *Read Luke 1–2 and John 1:1–18. Lesson 19 opens Unit 5: the silence breaks, and the Word becomes flesh.*

For Discussion

1. At the temple's foundation, many shouted for joy while the old men who had seen Solomon's temple wept. Why do you think both reactions made sense?
2. Haggai said, "Consider your ways." What would change if you put God's priorities ahead of your own projects?
3. Nehemiah prayed and also posted guards. How do prayer and practical action work together?
4. When Ezra read God's word, the people wept, and then were told to rejoice. Why do we need both?
5. The exiles came home to the land but kept drifting from God. Why is it possible to return outwardly without returning in your heart?
6. God was silent for four hundred years but kept working. Where have you seen God at work when he seemed silent?
7. Haggai promised the second temple's glory would be greater than the first. How did Jesus fulfill that?

Sources & For Further Study

- On the dates of the return (538, 516, 458, 445 BC): Eugene H. Merrill, *Kingdom of Priests*; Edwin M. Yamauchi, *Persia and the Bible*.
- On the intertestamental period: Anthony J. Tomasino, *Judaism Before Jesus*. On Daniel 9: Iain M. Duguid, *Daniel* (Reformed Expository Commentary); O. Palmer Robertson, *The Christ of the Prophets*.
- For further reading: Derek Kidner, *Ezra and Nehemiah* (Tyndale Old Testament Commentaries); Iain M. Duguid, *Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi* (EP Study Commentary).



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